of vigilance bureau investigations. Channi belongs to the Ramdasi Sikh community and is considered close to the deras of the community.

BJP candidate Atwal is a Mazhabi Sikh. His father Charanjit Atwal was the joint candidate of the SAD-BJP in 2019, and had lost to Chaudhary by about 19,000 votes. The Valmiki/Mazhabi Sikh has challenged the Ramdasi/Ravidasi/Adi Dharmi bloc in Jalandhar in the past, and the AAP, SAD, Congress and SAD (Amritsar)'s candidates hail from this bloc. Atwal is hoping to reap this trend and mine his father's legacy. Traditionally, the BJP hasn't had cadre in rural Punjab. It has therefore resorted to using inorganic means of defections to build strength. Atwal's entry into the BJP, just days before the nomination process, has caused considerable heartburn in the local BJP.

The saffron party's biggest setback, though, was the exit of Mohinder Bhagat. The Bhagat Dalit community has significant presence in the assembly segments of Jalandhar West and Jalandhar Cantt. The BJP fears he may take his support base with him. To keep their chances alive, the BJP made his father and former minister Chunni Lal Bhagat convene a press conference, in which he distanced himself from his son's actions. However, Punjab's rural population hasn't really forgiven the BJP, first for the Union government's three farm laws in 2020 and more recently because of the action against controversial Khalistan propagandist Amritpal. AAP, too, has lost the panthic voters' sympathy over Amritpal, which Sukhbir's SAD is now hoping to attract, as does Simranjit Mann. CM Mann is hoping he can make amends with his relief measures to compensate farmers for loss of yield on account of the unseasonal rains in March. The Congress, SAD and the BJP are contesting the claims. Ultimately, one expects, it will be the glorious uncertainties of politics that will prevail. ■

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If you see flashing lights in your rear view mirror and hear the siren of an emergency service vehicle, move out of the lane immediately to help clear the path to life. Fire tenders, ambulances, police vehicles, all have the right of way in case of emergencies which these vehicles warn you of with sirens and flashing lights. Basic thumb rule is pull to the left and slow down to let emergency service vehicles safely pass. Also, slow down and let those in front of you switch lanes to ensure the emergency service vehicle's path is cleared as quickly as possible. If you are on a two-lane road without a median and there's an emergency service vehicle approaching from the opposite side, even then the right way is to pull to the leftmost part of the road. Your actions could be the difference between life and death. On certain highways, the shoulder is designated as the emergency vehicle lane, so avoid blocking it. Also, do not tailgate, say an ambulance, in the hope of getting through traffic quicker. In most cases these vehicles will anyway be going over prescribed speed limits. Let them pass, and carry on following the rules as you should. As per section 194E MV Act 1988 (amended 2019), if a vehicle fails to pull to the side of the road or block the way of an ambulance, or any other emergency service vehicle, the driver may be punished with imprisonment of up to six months or with a fine of Rs 10,000 or both. That's the law, but the whole idea behind helping you #BeTheBetterGuy is to make you do the right thing as a responsible citizen and not because of the fear of the law. ■

